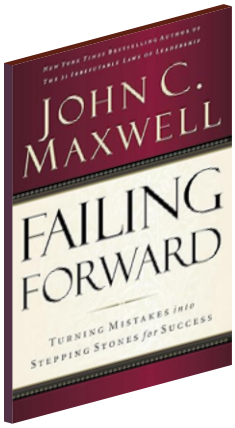
# *Failing Forward: Turning Mistakes into Stepping Stones for Success*
## by John C. Maxwell

Reading Time:
10 minutes




**What if failure was not the opposite of success, but its foundation?** What truly separates those who succeed from those who merely get by? John C. Maxwell's answer is as simple as it is powerful: it's not talent, luck, or circumstances. It's how they deal with failure. In *Failing Forward*, Maxwell dismantles the fear of falling short and redefines failure as an essential part of growth, resilience, and long-term success. Through a 15-step guide, practical strategies, memorable quotes, and powerful real-life stories, he shows that failure is not something to be feared or avoided—but faced, understood, and transformed into a tool for learning.

**This mindset shift is not just for individuals. In a world where uncertainty is the new constant, organizations too must embrace a culture that turns mistakes into momentum. That's why *Failing Forward* is part of WOBI's curated selection 7 Must-Read Books for Future-Proofing Your Business. This list equips leaders with tools to anticipate change, build resilience, and cultivate long-term vision—qualities Maxwell champions by encouraging us to fail fast, learn constantly, and move forward with purpose.**



## About the Author

**John C. Maxwell** (1947) is a leadership expert and author of over 100 books - with over 19 million copies, including the New York Times bestseller, *The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership*. He has influenced millions globally with his practical insights on leadership, personal growth, and success.

## Step #1:
# Realize the difference between high achievers and average people.

**Between people who succeed and those who don't lies one key trait: how they perceive and respond to failure**. The fear of failure limits ambition more than failure itself ever could. Maxwell highlights a powerful shift: don't imagine a world without failure—instead, change how you relate to it. The goal is not to remove the risk of falling, but to stop letting that risk define your vision. Because every success worth achieving comes with setbacks.

> *"What would you pursue if failure stopped scaring you?"* - John C. Maxwell

## Step #2:
# Learn a new definition of failure.

**Failure is not about the event—it's about how we interpret it.** People often misjudge failure by reacting too quickly, labeling setbacks as definitive rather than part of a broader journey. Maxwell emphasizes that failure is unavoidable, subjective, and often misunderstood. The key is to change your perception: see failure as temporary, not irreversible; as a teacher, not a stigma. True failure only occurs when you stop learning and growing. Each mistake is a step upward—if you're willing to learn from it.

***Rule #1:***
*You must learn lessons.*

***Rule #2:***
*There are no mistakes, only lessons.*

***Rule #3:***
*A lesson is repeated until it is learned.*

***Rule #4:***
*If you don't learn the easy lessons, they get harder (pain is the universe's way of getting your attention).*

***Rule #5:***
*You'll know you've learned a lesson when your actions change.*

## Step #3:
# Remove the YOU from failure.

**"The first truly important step in managing failure is learning not to personalize it."** And it all begins when we take failure personally, allowing fear to dictate our behavior. The most successful people don't avoid rejection or setbacks; they reject the idea that failure defines them. Maxwell outlines seven traits of resilient people: the key isn't avoiding failure... It's building the mindset to grow through it.

***Trait #1: They reject rejection –*** *They take responsibility but don't internalize failure.*

***Trait #2: They view failure as temporary –*** *It's just a moment, not a defining truth.*

***Trait #3: They see failure as isolated –*** *One bad event doesn't define who they are.*

***Trait #4: They are realistic in their expectations –*** *Big dreams require big mental preparation.*

***Trait #5: They focus on what they can do –*** *They improve what they can and work on their character when needed.*

***Trait #6: They change strategies –*** *They adjust and adapt instead of giving up.*

***Trait #7: They keep trying –*** *All achievers persist through setbacks.*

*"Examine your expectations. Are they realistic? Are you expecting to succeed on the first try? Adjust, explore new approaches, and commit to not giving up."* - John C. Maxwell

## Step #4:
# Take action and reduce fear!

As Viktor Frankl, neurologist, psychologist, and philosopher warned, fear often manifests exactly what we're trying to avoid.

*"The most useless person,"* says Tom Peters, coauthor of *In Search of Excellence, "is someone who ends their day proudly thinking, 'Well, I got through the day without any trouble.'"* That's what many people who fear failure do.

⚠ *A cycle you don't want to experience: When someone can't overcome the fear of failure, they get trapped in a dangerous loop:*

1. *Self-pity – They feel sorry for themselves and eventually stop taking responsibility, seeing themselves as victims.*
2. *Excuses – A person may fall many times, but they only become a failure when they start blaming others. Making excuses adds a second mistake to the first.*
3. *Wasted Energy – Fear scatters the mind, drains focus, and divides attention. With no clear direction, there's no progress.*
4. *Hopelessness – If fear and inaction are left unchecked, they gradually rob a person of hope.*

***How to break the cycle?***

*Start acting even if you're not motivated.*

*Here's the secret: once you begin, motivation kicks in. Action leads to energy and progress.*

## Step #5:
# Change your response to failure by accepting responsibility.

**Failure isn't a weakness—it's a sign of growth.** Trying, failing, reflecting, and trying again is how progress happens. Maxwell states that covering up failure wastes energy; using it to fuel your next move is far more productive. The path forward begins not with waiting for the "right feeling," but with **taking action**, even when you're uncertain. Confidence and momentum are built *along the way*. As American author H. Stanley Judd notes: *"if you're not failing, you're not growing."* Mistakes, in truth, **pave the road to success.**

> Peter Drucker, leadership expert, said: *"The better the man, the more mistakes he will make, because he'll be trying to do new things."*

## Step #6:
# Don't let failure from outside get inside.

**Failure doesn't begin with circumstance—it begins within.** You may face painful external challenges, but what determines whether you fall or rise is your inner posture. As the Danish proverb reminds us: *"It's not the cards you're dealt, but how you play them."* True resilience isn't about suppressing emotions or pretending everything's fine—it's about cultivating a hopeful, proactive attitude even in hardship. Contentment, Maxwell shows, comes not from control or achievement, but from **how you think and act** in the face of adversity. Defeat isn't imposed—it's accepted.

***True contentment comes from a positive attitude, which includes:***

- ***Expecting the best, not the worst.***
- ***Maintaining a spirit of victory, even when you feel defeated.***
- ***Seeking solutions in every problem, not problems in every solution.***
- ***Believing in yourself, even when others think you've failed.***
- ***Holding on to hope, even when others have given up on the situation.***

> *"Man is not defeated by his opponents, but by himself."* – Jan Christiaan Smuts, Prime Minister of the Union of South Africa (1919-1924; 1939-1948)

## Step #7:
# Say goodbye to yesterday.

**Failure isn't a weakness—it's a sign of growth.** The past can be a prison—or a platform. Maxwell highlights that **no successful person lives anchored to past failures**. Lingering too long in yesterday's pain can lead to comparison, justification, isolation, regret, or bitterness. These emotional patterns drain energy and block progress. But every painful experience is also a choice point: let it define you or drive you. Because resilience isn't forgetting what happened—it's refusing to let it hold you back.

**Signs of Unresolved Past Crises**

- **Comparison:** Constantly talking about how much worse you've had it compared to others usually signals someone who is still captive to their past.
- **Rationalization:** Another trait of people stuck in the past is justifying why they can't move forward—believing there are good reasons not to let go of old struggles.
- **Isolation:** Many people retreat due to past wounds. For naturally extroverted individuals, isolation can worsen their condition.
- **Regret:** A major obstacle to living in the present. Regret drains energy and leaves little for constructive action.
- **Bitterness:** When someone doesn't heal old wounds, they eventually become bitter. It's the inevitable outcome of not processing pain and tragedy.

*Maxwell invites us to release past pain—not by denying it, but by processing it fully: feel the loss, forgive, and then free yourself. Holding on to suffering keeps you stuck in a life you're merely preparing for—but never living. Take time now to make a list of the negative things from your past that might be holding you hostage:*

***Acknowledge the pain*** → ***Grieve what was lost*** → ***Forgive the person*** → ***Forgive yourself*** → ***Let go—and move on***

## Step #8:
# Change yourself and your world changes.

True growth begins with clarity, drive, and consistency. Know what you want, take action toward it, and don't stop. Healing and success both begin when you stop being your own obstacle. As Jean Valjean declared in Les Misérables by Victor Hugo: ***"To die is nothing. The terrible thing is not to live."***

- *Not knowing what you want is a problem of knowledge.*
- *Not trying to get it is a problem of motivation.*
- *Not achieving it is a problem of persistence.*

## Step #9:
# Get over yourself and start giving!

**The fastest way to grow—and feel fulfilled—is to stop centering everything around yourself.** Maxwell argues that *"transformation begins when you shift from self-focus to service."* People who add value to others create deeper impact, and ironically, experience more meaning in their own lives. Want to move forward? Start outward. Be the reason someone else's life improves. Focus on generosity, empathy, and contribution. In the end, success isn't about status—it's about significance and connection. Comedian Victor Borge put it perfectly: *"Laughter is the shortest distance between two people."*

*"When people think of you, do they say to themselves, 'Is my life better because of this person?'"*
- John C. Maxwell

*How do you stop focusing on yourself and start focusing on others? You can do it by:*

- *Putting others first in your thoughts.*
- *Discovering what others need.*
- *Meeting those needs with excellence and generosity.*

## Step #10:
# Find the good in bad experiences.

**Failure isn't about doing something wrong—it's about *not learning* from it.** Maxwell warns that inspiration alone found in business events for example isn't enough. Events may feel exciting, but without consistent application, nothing changes. The true transformation lies in the process—day-to-day commitment, not one-time inspiration. And when adversity comes, as it inevitably does, it should be welcomed as a growth accelerator. It strengthens character, expands limits, and opens doors to innovation, opportunity, and motivation. In short: **adversity is a gift—if you let it shape you.**

**The Benefits of Adversity:**

*Builds resilience* *Develops maturity*

*Broadens what's considered acceptable performance* *Creates greater opportunities*

*Drives innovation* *Produces unexpected rewards* *Motivates*

*"A failure is someone who does things wrong and is unable to gain anything from the experience."* – Elbert Hubbard, American writer, publisher, artist, and philosopher.

# Step #11:
# Try something harder. Take a risk!

**Risk should be measured by the purpose behind it—not by fear or odds.** In this chapter, Maxwell explains that while the world values safety, visionaries like Amelia Earhart—and voices like Helen Keller's—knew that a meaningful life requires risk and risk is not measured by the lack of fear but by the importance of the mission. He narrates Amelia Earhart's story by starting with her goal: "My ambition," she said, "is to make this wonderful gift produce practical results for the future of commercial aviation and for women who want to fly the planes of tomorrow." Before departing in her final flights, she said, "*I feel I have one more good flight left in me, and I hope this is it.*" After covering 35,398 km, Earhart and her navigator disappeared on July 2, 1937. Their plane was never found.

> *"Security is mostly a superstition. In the long run, avoiding danger is no safer than outright exposure. Life is either a daring adventure or nothing at all."*
> - Helen Keller, American author, disability rights advocate, and political activist.

Most people don't fail because of lack of ability. They fail because they fall into subtle traps, mental obstacles that quietly block progress. Maxwell challenges us to confront these traps, take action, and stay aligned with our goals.

**Traps That Make People Unwilling to Move Forward:**

- ***The Shame Trap:*** *Don't wrap your failures in pretty paper. Let small mistakes go and move on.*
- ***The Rationalization Trap:*** *People stuck in this trap doubt themselves endlessly and never take action.*
- ***The Unrealistic Expectations Trap:*** *Many expect life to be easy—and quit when they realize effort is required. Success takes hard work.*
- ***The Justice Trap:*** *Expecting life to always be fair will only lead to frustration.*
- ***The Time Trap:*** *"If there's no wind, row." – Latin Proverb. There's never a perfect time—just start. William James put it well: "Nothing tires more than unfinished work."*
- ***The Inspiration Trap:*** *"You don't have to feel like starting—just start to feel like it." Oscar Wilde noted the difference between amateurs and professionals: amateurs write when they feel inspired; professionals write regardless of how they feel.*

## Step #12:
# Learn from bad experience and strive for success.

Real progress is earned by those who aren't afraid to stumble, ask hard questions, and seek counsel from people who've been through the fire. **Wisdom is not just about learning from wins, but about extracting value from your losses**. Success, ultimately, belongs to the *humble learners*—not the self-proclaimed experts.

**Questions to ask yourself in adversity:**

1. ***What caused this failure—circumstances, someone else, or me?***
2. ***Was this truly a failure, or just falling short?***
3. ***What factors were at play?***
4. ***What can I learn from what happened?***
5. ***Am I grateful for the experience?***
6. ***How can I turn this into success?***
7. ***Who can help me? Seek advice—but only from those who've learned to fail successfully.***

William Bolitho, journalist, writer and biographer, drew a line between the wise and the foolish: *"The most important thing inz life is not to capitalize on our gains. Any fool can do that. The real skill lies in profiting from our losses. That requires intelligence—and it marks the difference between a wise person and a fool."*

## Step #13:
# Work on the weakness.

**Failure often doesn't stem from a single major mistake—but from a combination of subtle, recurring behaviors and blind spots.** Maxwell outlines ten common reasons why people fall short. Most are within our control: mindset, focus, commitment, adaptability, and goal-setting. Even talent, if relied on exclusively, becomes a trap. The key to moving forward is recognizing these patterns, owning them, and shifting course. Because success isn't built on avoiding mistakes—but on correcting the habits that cause them.

**10 Reasons Why People Fail:**

1. *Poor ability to understand others*
2. *A negative attitude*
3. *Bad fit (in a role, job, or environment)*
4. *Lack of focus*
5. *Weak commitment*
6. *Unwillingness to change*
7. *Minimum-effort mindset*
8. *Relying only on talent*
9. *Reacting poorly to limited or bad information*
10. *Absence of clear goals*

## Step #14:
# Understand there's no difference between success and failure.

And yet there is one... persistence. Growth begins with honesty: identify your weaknesses, and then commit to strengthening them. Maxwell emphasizes that **transformation is intentional**—it's not just about pressing forward blindly, but about doing so with purpose and structure. The formula is simple but powerful: name your weakness, keep moving, and celebrate progress step by step.

**The Power of Persistence:**

1. ***Purpose:*** *Have one.*
2. ***Excuses:*** *Eliminate them.*
3. ***Incentives:*** *Create some. Reward yourself only after reaching a goal. Break the process into stages to multiply the sense of achievement.*

## Step #15:
# Get up, get over and get going.

**Experience isn't about what happens—it's about how you grow from it.** Maxwell stresses that without a goal, there's no plan. Without a plan, no action. And without action, no results. Preparation is essential, but it's only half the equation—execution is the other. Success requires aligning vision with motion. The old saying (coined by Benjamin Franklin) still holds true: *"By failing to prepare, you are preparing to fail."* Likewise, Spanish author Miguel de Cervantes said: *"He who prepares has already won half the battle."*

The road forward is built with clarity, action, and a willingness to let experience teach what knowledge alone never could.

> *"Experience is not what happens to you. It's what you do with what happens to you."*
> – Aldous Huxley, English writer and Philosopher

## To sum up...

# The 15 steps:

**Step 15:** Get up, get over and get going.

**Step 14:** Understand there's no difference between success and failure.

**Step 13:** Work on the weakness.

**Step 12:** Learn from bad experience and strive for success.

**Step 11:** Try something harder. Take a risk!

**Step 10:** Find the good in bad experiences.

**Step 9:** Get over yourself and start giving!

**Step 8:** Change yourself and your world changes.

**Step 7:** Say goodbye to yesterday.

**Step 6:** Don't let failure from outside get inside.

**Step 5:** Change your response to failure by accepting responsibility.

**Step 4:** Take action and reduce fear!

**Step 3:** Remove the YOU from failure.

**Step 2:** Learn a new definition of failure.

**Step 1:** Realize the difference between high achievers and average people.

# Editor's Note

In *Failing Forward,* John C. Maxwell reframes failure from a source of embarrassment into a **platform for growth**. This perspective is invaluable in today's fast-changing, innovative world, where the willingness to experiment (and sometimes fail) is often the difference between staying average and achieving excellence. Maxwell's insights align perfectly with WOBI's philosophy of continuous learning and adaptability. He reminds us that **failure is not a tattoo; it's just a bruis**e – it heals with time, and you come back wiser. The book ultimately inspires a sense of hope and resilience: No matter how many times you've fallen or how big your missteps, you can begin anew and use that experience to propel yourself higher.

The takeaway for all readers and leaders is clear: **Choose to fail forward**. Adopt an attitude of **learning**, **persistence, and optimism**, and you'll find that each mistake actually *strengthens* you. As Maxwell shows through countless examples, from entrepreneurs to athletes to pioneers like Amelia Earhart, those who ultimately succeed aren't those who never failed – they're those who **refused to let failure defeat them**. They extracted wisdom from disappointment, kept their ambitions alive, and tried again and again until they prevailed. In the end, Failing Forward teaches that the only real failure is not learning from what you did – and the only way to true success is through courageous attempts, resilient recoveries, and an unwavering commitment to **growth**. Embrace your mistakes, and you'll find that each one becomes a stepping stone on your journey to success.

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